happened in Maharashtra and Karnataka where the NDDB had been called in to overhaul local milk cooperative operations and was, some say unfairly, targeted for the Gujarat connection. Karnataka had seen a huge controversy erupt in 2023 during election time with allegations being made, again, that it was an underhand move to allow Amul to make inroads at the cost of local brand Nandini. In Maharashtra earlier this year, the takeover of Mahanand Dairy by the NDDB had elicited charges of land grab and job losses besides the usual plaint of business moving to Gujarat at the expense of the local industry.

CM Mohan Yadav, though, dismisses the allegations, saying the takeover would help enhance incomes of dairy farmers. Currently, average per capita availability of milk in MP is 644 gm (national average is 459 gm), and the state is targeting a doubling of milk production in five years, says Yadav.

Meanwhile, political analysts also see the proposed takeover as a move to strengthen the CM's hand involving identity politics and his own Yadav community. They point to how there has been a substantial increase in allocations to the animal husbandry department in the 2024-25 budget. "The NDDB is a respected body and I think the takeover would help dairy farmers in MP, especially since there have been issues with Sanchi," says senior journalist N.K. Singh. "However, there is a downside—an inhouse brand will in the short term be weakened and this could lead to other players in the sector becoming stronger."

The dairy sector's potential was recognised even by former BJP chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, with his sons embarking on a dairy business some years ago. Will CM Mohan Yadav be the next to milk its potential? One will have to wait and watch. ■



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NOT ON THE SAME PAGE
J&K LG Manoj Sinha greets CM Omar Abdullah at the latter's swearing-in ceremony, Srinagar, Oct. 16

JAMMU & KASHMIR

COMPETING FOR TURF

By Kaleem Geelani

As a thick late autumn mist envelops the Valley, the first elected government in the Union Territory in six years is still feeling its way around. The new National Conference government's first move was unambiguous enough—a resolution for the restoration of statehood for Jammu & Kashmir. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah presented the resolution—passed then duly in the maiden cabinet meeting on October 17—to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah on October 24 in New Delhi. On November 4, the J&K assembly held its first session in six years, with Waheed ur Rehman Parra, the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) MLA from Pulwama, stealing the show by attempting—in vain—to move a resolution against the August 2019 decision to abrogate Article 370. However, Omar's elected government knows its limitations—in the UT, key powers rest with Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha.

The desperate need among the Kashmiri parties to regain statehood was evident in the legislators' boycott of the Union Territory Foundation Day at the Sher-i-Kashmir International Convention Centre by the Dal Lake in Srinagar on October 31. While the absence of leaders from the ruling party—and those from the PDP and Congress—